



NODUS · COMPLETE VAULT GUIDE

Databases

Build approachable relational datasets, inspect quality and analyse patterns.

The Databases vault provides typed tables, relations, formulas, rollups, views, search, analysis and grounded data chat without requiring a separate database server.

VERSION	Nodus 4.1
UPDATED	14 August 2026
AUDIENCE	Researchers, collections teams and anyone whose project has outgrown a spreadsheet.

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Core operation, configuration and the complete vault workflow.

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PART I · FOUNDATION

Core Nodus workflow

Start here if Nodus is new to you. These chapters explain what a vault is, how to move through the application, how sources remain traceable, when a model is optional and how to keep a recoverable copy of the work.

START HERE

1 Welcome to Nodus

Nodus is a local-first desktop workspace for research, teaching and study. Work is organised into focused vaults that share one private engine.

A vault is an independent workspace for one project, course, family or dataset. Changing the vault changes the navigation and assistant context, while the database, indexes and preserved files stay on the computer. Accounts are optional, and model-assisted features run only after a provider or local model has been configured.

WHERE TO FIND IT

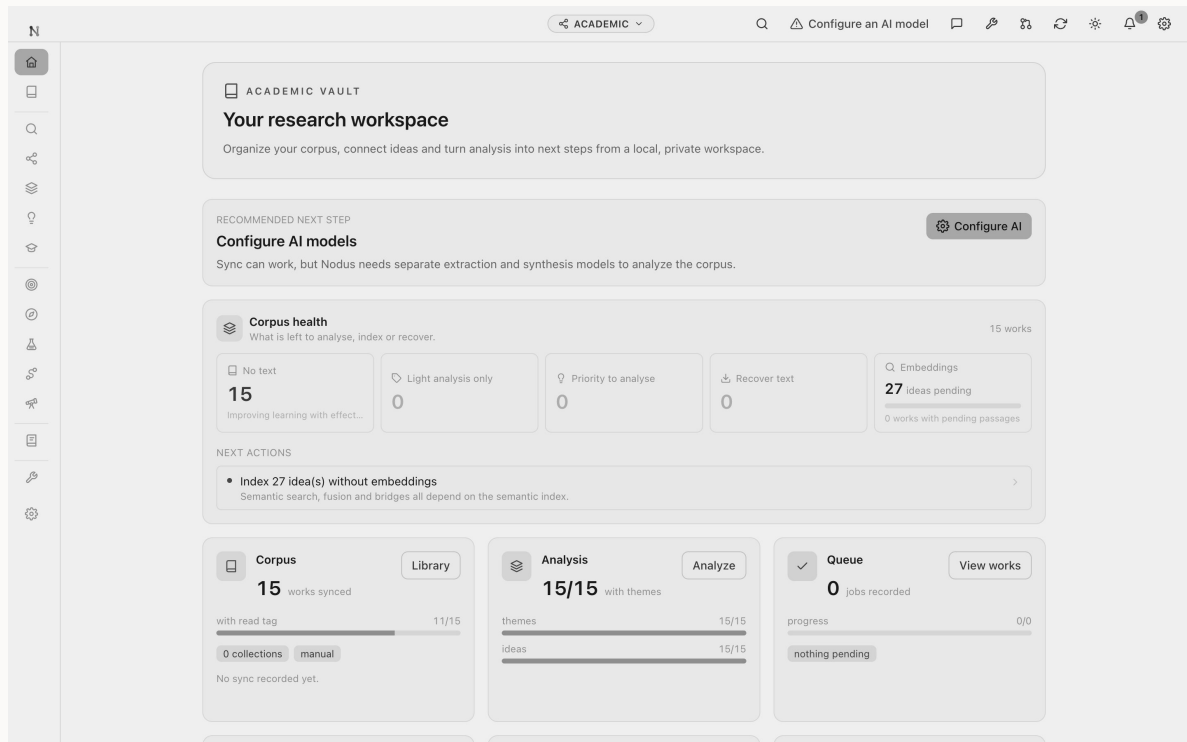
Install Nodus, then open the application

STEP BY STEP

1. Download the package for macOS, Windows or Linux from the Nodus release page and complete the installer.
2. Launch Nodus and complete the short setup: appearance, optional Nodi assistant and the introductory tour.
3. Create the vault that matches the work you are starting, give it a clear name and remain on Home while you learn the layout.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use one vault per coherent project, course, family or dataset.
- Start with a small set of real material that you are allowed to process.



Welcome to Nodus in the Nodus desktop application

START HERE

2 Create and switch vaults

Create independent workspaces and move between them without mixing their context.

The vault switcher is the boundary between projects. Each vault has its own notes, analysis and domain records, while the global Library can link the same source into compatible vaults without duplicating it.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Application header → vault name and icon

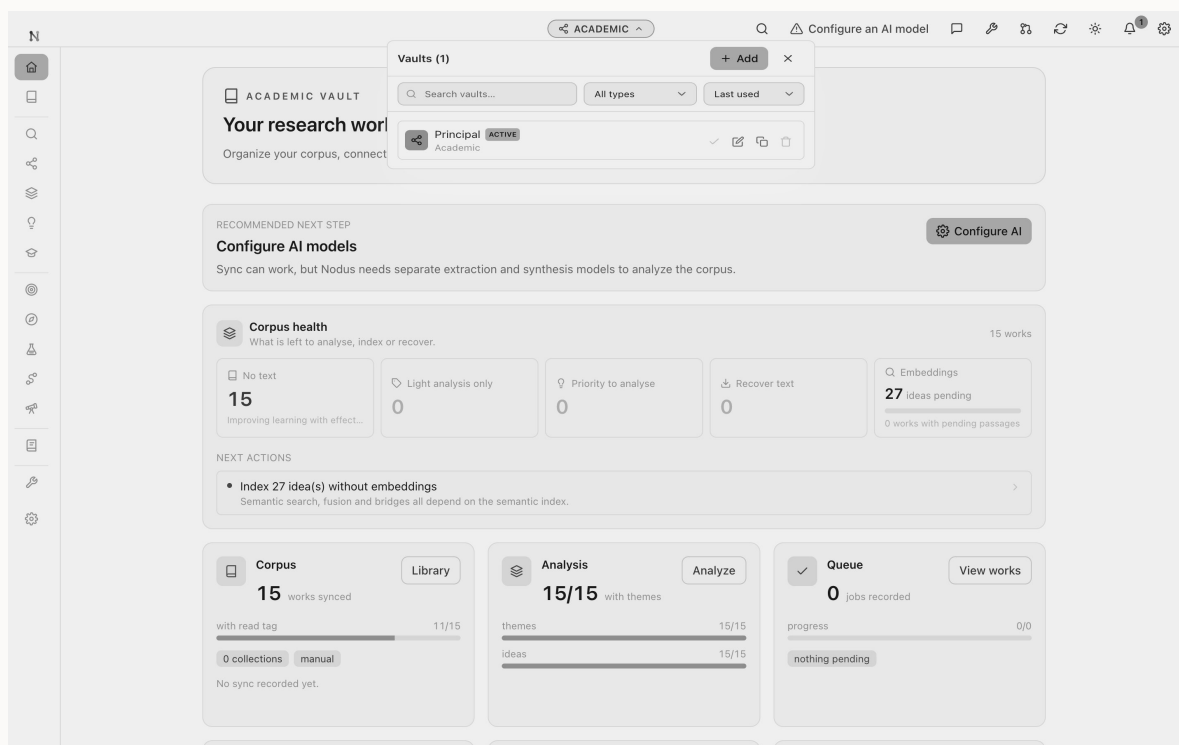
STEP BY STEP

1. Select the current vault name in the centre of the application header, then choose the action to create a vault.
2. Enter a descriptive name, select the correct vault type and read the explanation of the workflow it enables before confirming.
3. Open the same switcher whenever you need another project; choose a vault and wait for its Home view to appear.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use explicit names such as 'MA thesis - memory' or 'Biology 2026'.

- Create a new vault instead of changing the meaning of a mature workspace.



Create and switch vaults in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

3 Navigation and global search

The sidebar exposes the workflow for the active vault; search retrieves material across the relevant local index.

The narrow left sidebar contains the active vault's tools. Hover an icon to read its label. The magnifying-glass button opens search, while the vault button in the header changes workspace. Keyword search works immediately; semantic retrieval also requires an embedding model.

WHERE TO FIND IT

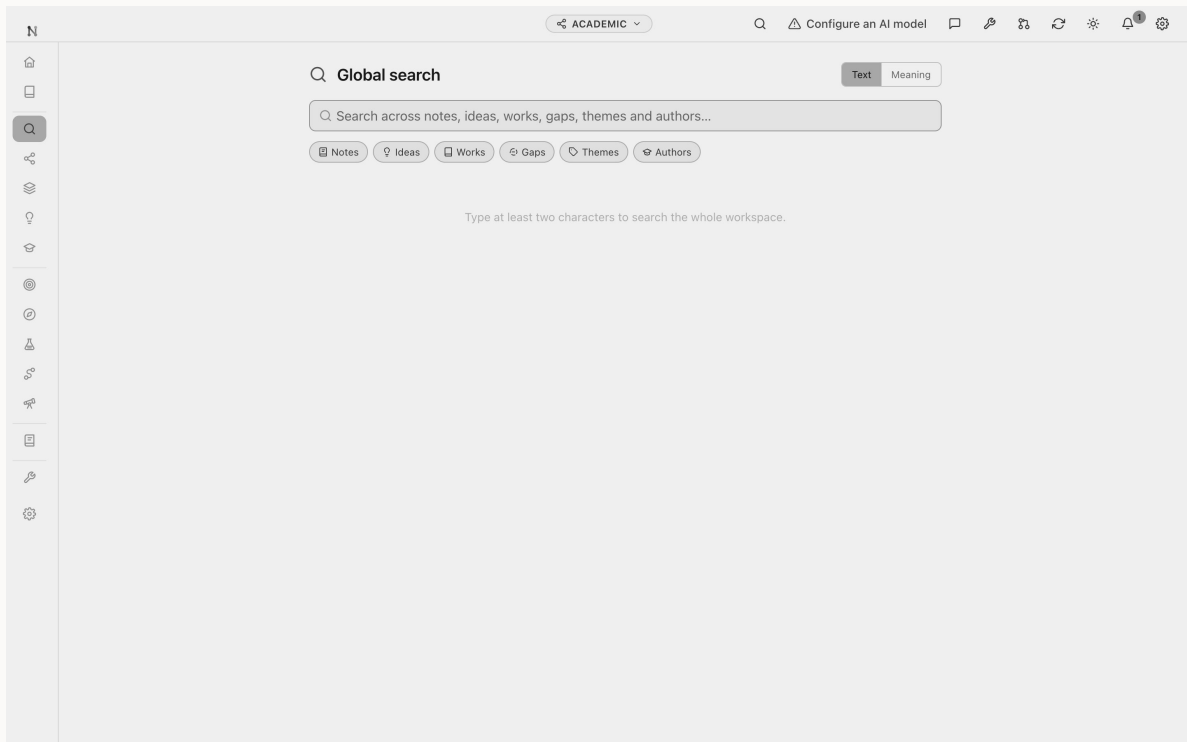
Left sidebar → magnifying-glass icon

STEP BY STEP

1. Move the pointer over sidebar icons until the label for the section you need appears, then select it; the active icon receives the vault colour.
2. Open Search and enter a title, name, quotation or concept of at least two meaningful characters.
3. Apply a type or scope filter when available, open a result and follow its source link to the original document, record, person or note.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Search for concepts as well as exact titles.
- Rebuild an index from Settings if recently imported content does not appear.



Navigation and global search in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

4 Library, sources and reader

Keep preserved originals beside clean reading copies, citations, highlights and extracted evidence.

The cross-vault Library can mirror Zotero, import RIS, BibTeX and CSL JSON, or accept files directly. Nodus preserves the original attachment and creates searchable derivatives. Compatible sources can be linked to several vaults without copying the original.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Nodus → Library, sources and reader

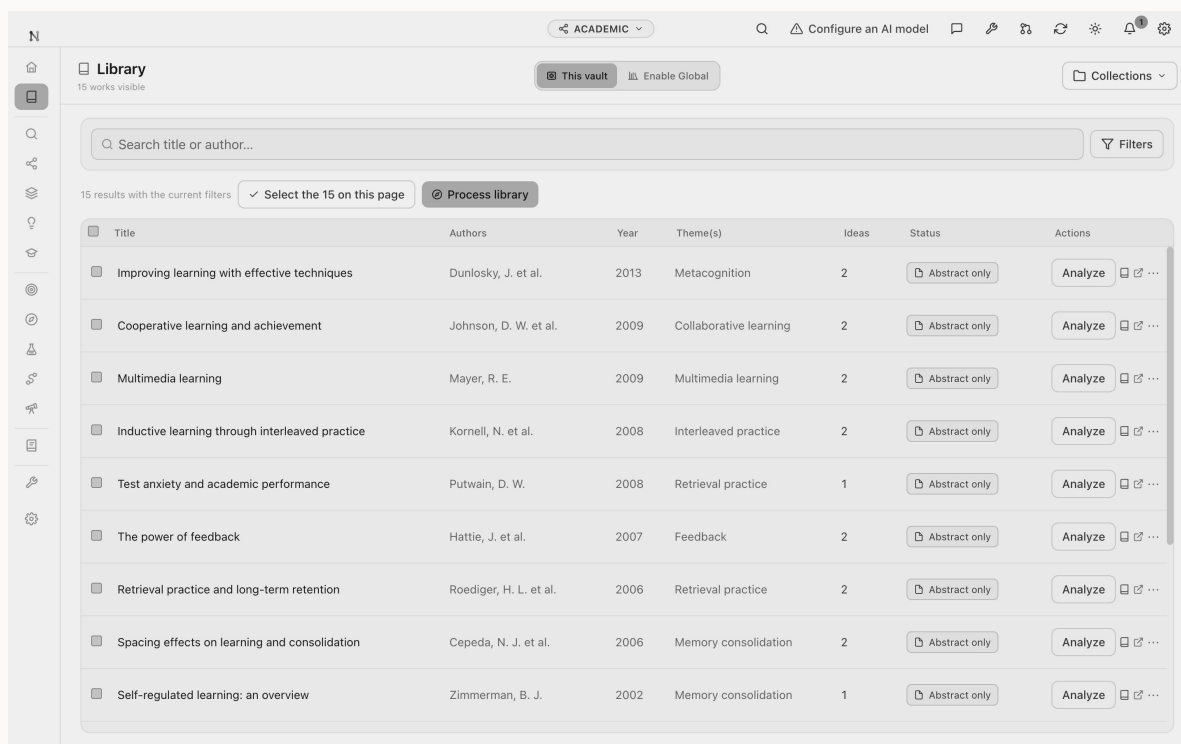
STEP BY STEP

1. Open Library and add a local file, import bibliographic data or connect Zotero.
2. Place the item in a collection and add useful tags; wait for extraction and indexing to finish.

3. Open the item, choose the clean reading copy or preserved original, then highlight passages and link the item into the active vault.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the preserved original for page-accurate verification.
- Treat automatically extracted text and metadata as a first pass that may need correction.



Library, sources and reader in the Nodus desktop application

CONFIGURATION

5 AI providers and task models

Bring your own cloud key or use compatible local models, with a different model for each task.

Nodus can be used without a model for deterministic organisation and editing. Features that generate, explain or synthesise text need a configured provider or compatible local endpoint. Provider keys are stored in the operating-system keychain, and task models let extraction, chat and reports use different choices.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Left sidebar → Settings → AI and providers

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings and find the AI provider section. Choose a cloud provider or enter the address of a compatible local endpoint.
2. Enter the required credential, use the connection test and resolve any error before continuing.
3. Assign a model to each available task, save the settings and test it on a small, non-sensitive source.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A local model improves privacy but may require more memory and time.
- Review every generated claim against its linked evidence.

CONFIGURATION

6 Privacy, backups and recovery

Protect local work with a verified backup and understand exactly when network services are used.

Vault databases, indexes and library files are local by default. Backups can include all vaults and the shared Library. Nodus reports backup health and creates protected recovery copies before major migrations.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Nodus → Privacy, backups and recovery

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, choose a backup destination and enable automatic backups.
2. Run a manual backup, then use verification to confirm that its manifest and files are readable.
3. Review the privacy notice for each optional online feature before sending content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Store backups on a different physical device or a trusted encrypted location.
- Do not treat sync as a backup; keep versioned recovery copies.

CONFIGURATION

7 Toolkit and integrations

Convert, protect, translate, OCR and present documents, or connect Zotero, Word, MCP clients and Nodus Server.

Toolkit contains file utilities shared by every vault. Integrations are optional: Zotero supplies bibliographic material, Word can use selected Nodus context, MCP exposes approved local tools, and Nodus Server

publishes a selected copy rather than the source vault.

WHERE TO FIND IT

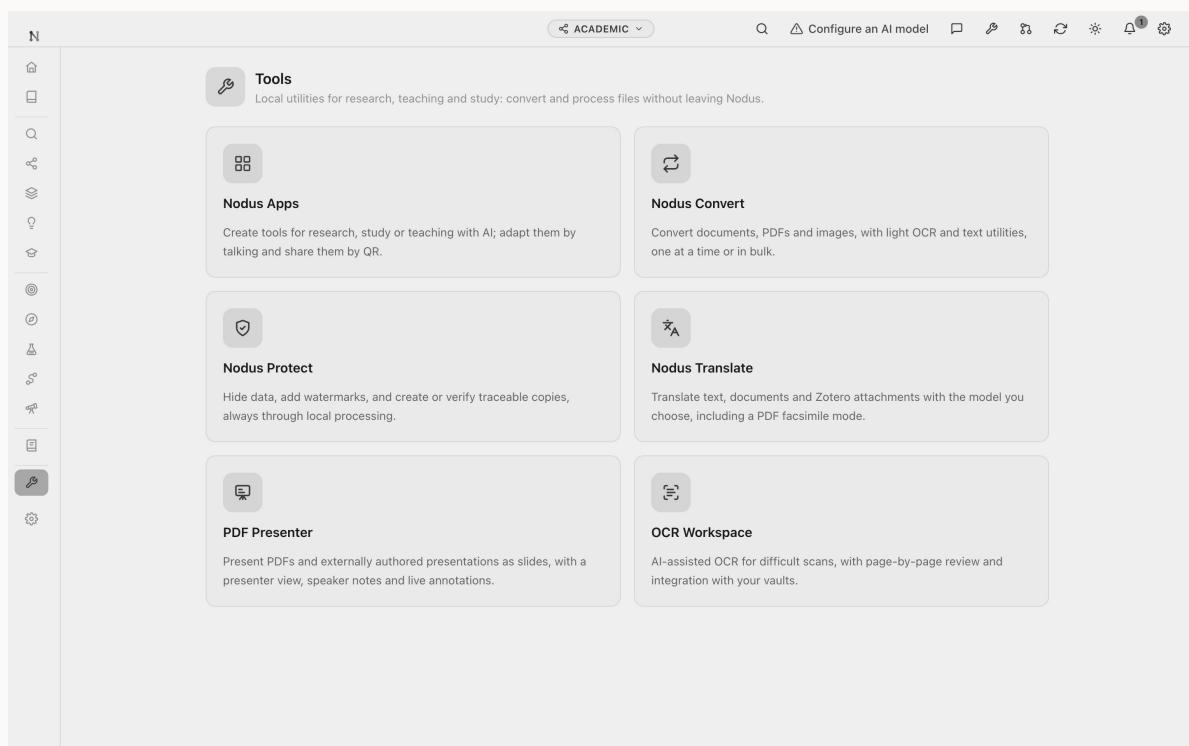
Left sidebar → wrench icon → Toolkit

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Toolkit and choose Convert, Protect, Translate, OCR Workspace or PDF Presenter.
2. Select a file from disk or a compatible vault source, then review every output option and destination.
3. For an integration, enable only the connector you need and test it with a non-sensitive file before using project material.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Permanent redaction in Protect is local and irreversible in the exported copy.
- Published server spaces should contain only material intended for their readers.

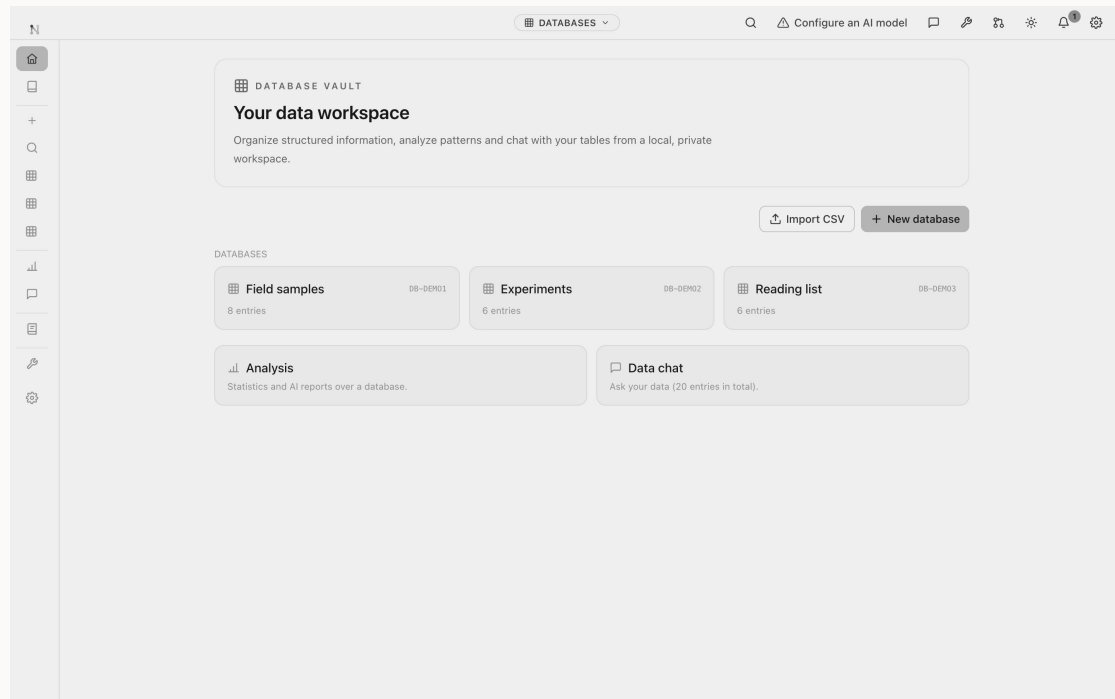


Toolkit and integrations in the Nodus desktop application

PART II • VAULT GUIDE

Complete Databases workflow

The Databases vault provides typed tables, relations, formulas, rollups, views, search, analysis and grounded data chat without requiring a separate database server.



Databases vault home in the Nodus desktop application

ORIENTATION

1 Home and database catalogue

Create, open and monitor the databases in a vault.

Home lists databases, row totals and shortcuts to search, analysis and data chat.

WHERE TO FIND IT

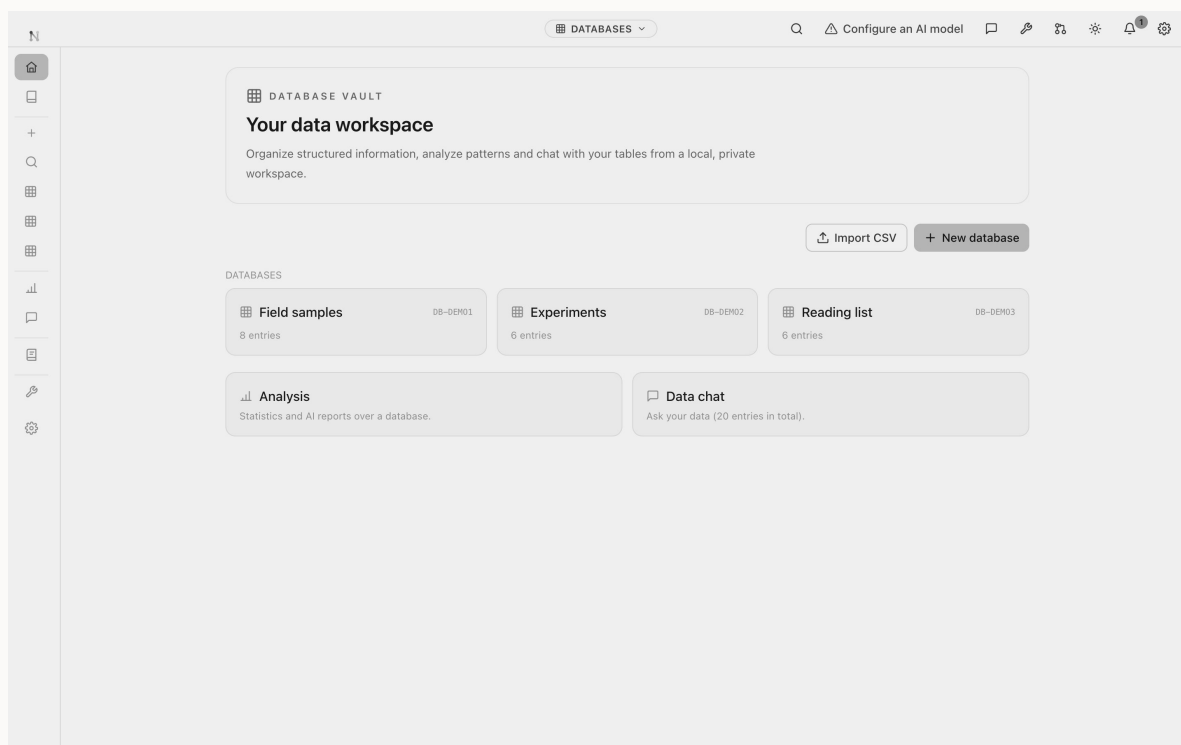
Databases vault → Home and database catalogue

STEP BY STEP

1. Create an empty database or import an existing CSV.
2. Give the database a specific name and description.
3. Open it from the catalogue or sidebar.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use separate databases for distinct entity types, then connect them with relations.



Home and database catalogue in the Nodus desktop application

BUILD

2 Columns and field types

Model text, numbers, dates, options, files, relations, formulas and AI-assisted outputs explicitly.

Typed fields make filtering, validation and analysis more reliable than a sheet of ambiguous strings. Schema changes should reflect the meaning of the data.

WHERE TO FIND IT

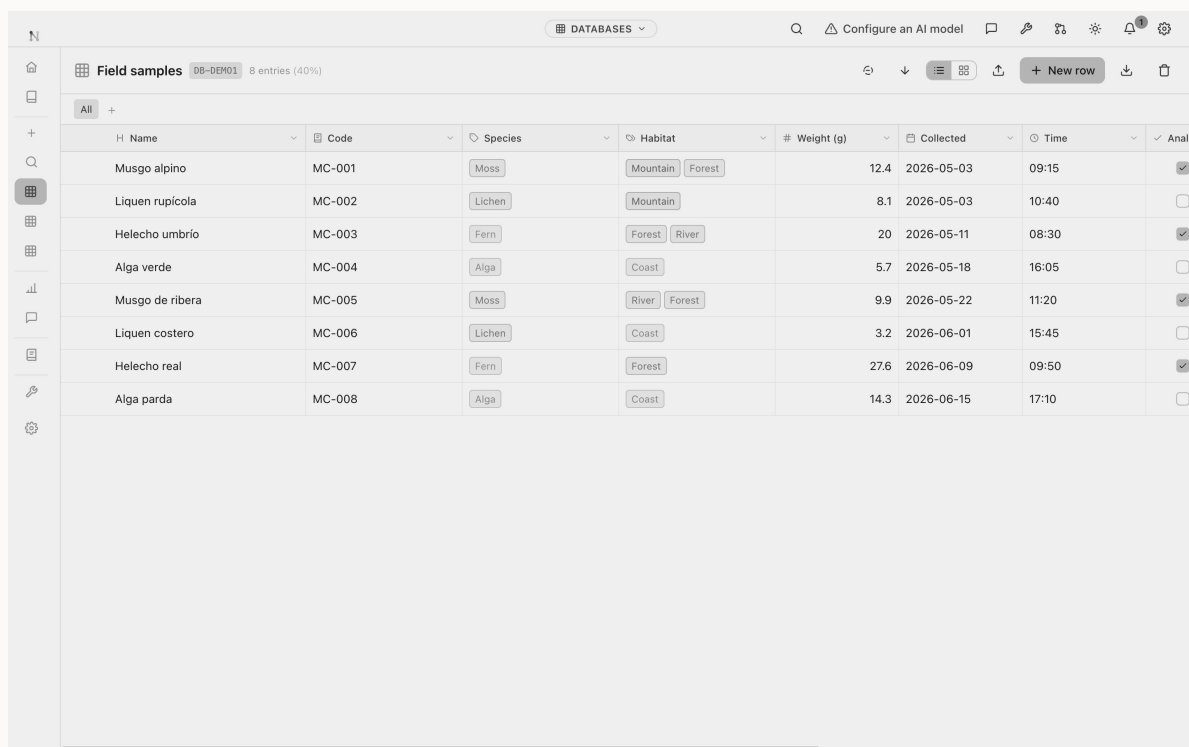
Databases vault → Columns and field types

STEP BY STEP

1. Add a column and choose the narrowest useful field type.
2. Name it in plain language and configure options, precision or validation.
3. Test the field on several records before bulk import.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Do not encode several facts in one text column if they must be filtered separately.



H Name	Code	Species	Habitat	# Weight (g)	Collected	Time	Anal.
Musgo alpino	MC-001	Moss	Mountain Forest	12.4	2026-05-03	09:15	☒
Liquen rupicola	MC-002	Lichen	Mountain	8.1	2026-05-03	10:40	☐
Helecho umbrio	MC-003	Fern	Forest River	20	2026-05-11	08:30	☒
Alga verde	MC-004	Alga	Coast	5.7	2026-05-18	16:05	☐
Musgo de ribera	MC-005	Moss	River Forest	9.9	2026-05-22	11:20	☒
Liquen costero	MC-006	Lichen	Coast	3.2	2026-06-01	15:45	☐
Helecho real	MC-007	Fern	Forest	27.6	2026-06-09	09:50	☒
Alga parda	MC-008	Alga	Coast	14.3	2026-06-15	17:10	☐

Columns and field types in the Nodus desktop application

BUILD

3 Rows and record detail

Edit records in the table or open a full record card with attachments and long fields.

Each row is a record. The detail view makes dense schemas easier to inspect and supports file attachments and extended content.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Databases vault → Rows and record detail

STEP BY STEP

1. Add a row and fill its identifying field first.
2. Edit compact values inline; open the record for long text, files or a complete audit.
3. Review required or invalid values before leaving the record.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Choose one stable field as the human-readable record title.

BUILD

4 Relations, formulas and rollups

Connect records and calculate derived values without copying data.

Relations link a row to records in another database. Rollups summarise related values, while formulas compute deterministic outputs from the current record.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Databases vault → Relations, formulas and rollups

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a relation column and choose its target database and cardinality.
2. Link existing records rather than retyping their names.
3. Add a rollup or formula, then test null values and edge cases.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Prefer relations over duplicated text when the referenced entity can change.

H Name	Code	Species	Habitat	# Weight (g)	Collected	Time	Anal.
Musgo alpino	MC-001	Moss	Mountain Forest	12.4	2026-05-03	09:15	✓
Liquen rupicola	MC-002	Lichen	Mountain	8.1	2026-05-03	10:40	□
Helecho umbrio	MC-003	Fern	Forest River	20	2026-05-11	08:30	✓
Alga verde	MC-004	Alga	Coast	5.7	2026-05-18	16:05	□
Musgo de ribera	MC-005	Moss	River Forest	9.9	2026-05-22	11:20	✓
Liquen costero	MC-006	Lichen	Coast	3.2	2026-06-01	15:45	□
Helecho real	MC-007	Fern	Forest	27.6	2026-06-09	09:50	✓
Alga parda	MC-008	Alga	Coast	14.3	2026-06-15	17:10	□

Relations, formulas and rollups in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

5 Table, gallery and saved views

Present the same records in layouts and filters suited to different tasks.

Views do not duplicate data. They store layout, visible fields, filters and sort order so a catalogue, review queue and fieldwork view can coexist.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Databases vault → Table, gallery and saved views

STEP BY STEP

1. Create or switch to Table or Gallery.
2. Choose visible fields and configure filter groups and sort order.
3. Save the view with a task-oriented name.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep one unfiltered audit view so hidden records are never mistaken for missing data.

EXPLORE

6 Filter, sort and bulk actions

Narrow records with explicit conditions and apply reviewed changes efficiently.

Filters can combine conditions; sorts establish a stable order. Bulk operations are powerful and should follow a preview or backup.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Databases vault → Filter, sort and bulk actions

STEP BY STEP

1. Add a filter condition, operator and value; group conditions deliberately.
2. Add one or more sort keys and check how blanks are ordered.
3. Select records, preview the bulk action and confirm only the intended fields.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Export or back up before irreversible bulk changes.

H Name	Code	Species	Habitat	# Weight (g)	Collected	Time	Anal.
Musgo alpino	MC-001	Moss	Mountain Forest	12.4	2026-05-03	09:15	☒
Liquen rupicola	MC-002	Lichen	Mountain	8.1	2026-05-03	10:40	☐
Helecho umbrío	MC-003	Fern	Forest River	20	2026-05-11	08:30	☒
Alga verde	MC-004	Alga	Coast	5.7	2026-05-18	16:05	☐
Musgo de ribera	MC-005	Moss	River Forest	9.9	2026-05-22	11:20	☒
Liquen costero	MC-006	Lichen	Coast	3.2	2026-06-01	15:45	☐
Helecho real	MC-007	Fern	Forest	27.6	2026-06-09	09:50	☒
Alga parda	MC-008	Alga	Coast	14.3	2026-06-15	17:10	☐

Filter, sort and bulk actions in the Nodus desktop application

EXCHANGE

7 CSV import and export

Bring in existing tabular data and export CSV, XLSX or JSON.

Import previews headers and type inference before writing rows. Export respects the selected database and format but may differ in how it represents relations or files.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Databases vault → CSV import and export

STEP BY STEP

1. Clean obvious duplicate headers, then open Import and preview encoding and delimiter.
2. Map each source column to a field and review inferred dates, numbers and options.
3. After import, check row count and samples; before export, choose the scope and target format.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the original import file unchanged as provenance.

EXPLORE

8 Cross-database search

Find database names and matching content inside rows.

Search spans every database in the vault and returns the record context needed to open the correct row.

WHERE TO FIND IT

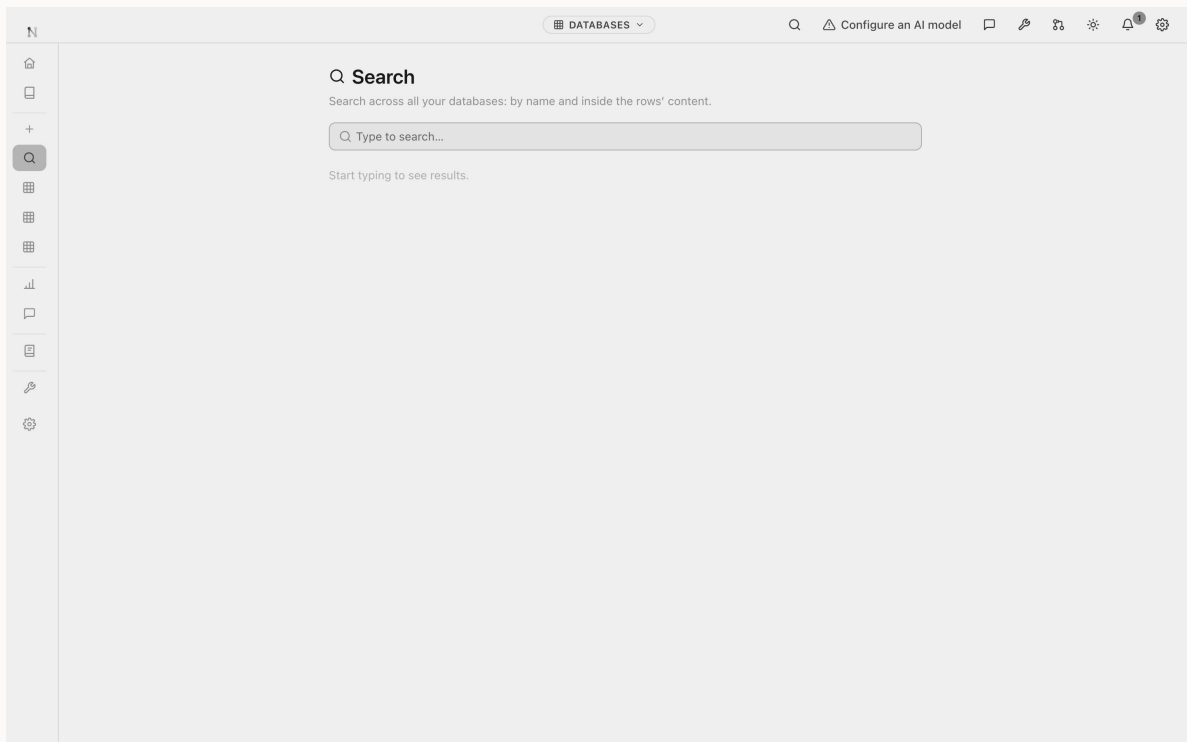
Databases vault → Cross-database search

STEP BY STEP

1. Enter a distinctive name, identifier or phrase.
2. Use database grouping to disambiguate similar records.
3. Open the row and verify the value in context.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Normalise identifiers and names to improve reliable retrieval.



Cross-database search in the Nodus desktop application

ANALYSE

9 Analysis and charts

Inspect distributions, missing values, summaries and visual patterns.

Deterministic statistics and charts run from the selected database. Model-assisted reports are optional and should cite the fields and populations used.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Databases vault → Analysis and charts

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a database and review row count, field completeness and detected types.
2. Select a categorical or numeric field for an appropriate chart.
3. Investigate outliers and missingness in the underlying rows before interpreting a pattern.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A chart is only as trustworthy as the schema and data-entry rules behind it.

ANALYSE

10 Data chat

Ask grounded questions about a selected database and receive inspectable summaries.

Data chat scopes answers to database rows rather than general knowledge. Responses may include computed summaries or charts, but important results should be checked against deterministic analysis.

WHERE TO FIND IT

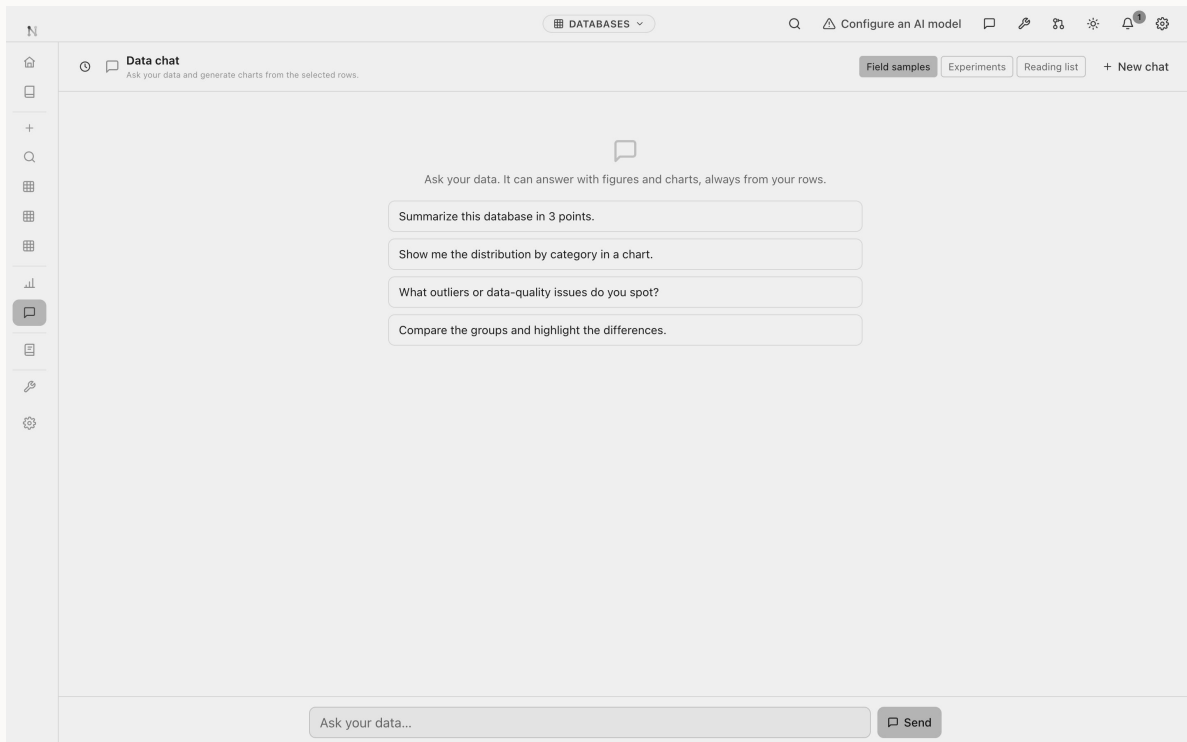
Databases vault → Data chat

STEP BY STEP

1. Select the target database.
2. Ask a precise question that names the measure, grouping and population.
3. Inspect cited or referenced records and reproduce critical totals in Analysis or export.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Ask for assumptions and missing-data treatment explicitly.



Data chat in the Nodus desktop application

ANALYSE

11 AI-assisted columns

Classify or summarise records into a new field under human review.

An AI column applies a defined instruction to selected record fields. Output is a proposal and can vary with model or prompt changes.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Databases vault → AI-assisted columns

STEP BY STEP

1. Create an AI-assisted field and define its input columns and expected output format.
2. Run it on a small sample and refine the instruction.
3. Review results before processing the full set and record the model configuration.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use deterministic formulas for calculations; reserve AI fields for interpretive tasks.

WRITE

12 Database-linked notes

Document definitions, cleaning decisions and interpretations beside the records.

Notes can link to databases and rows, providing an audit trail for decisions that do not fit in the schema itself.

WHERE TO FIND IT

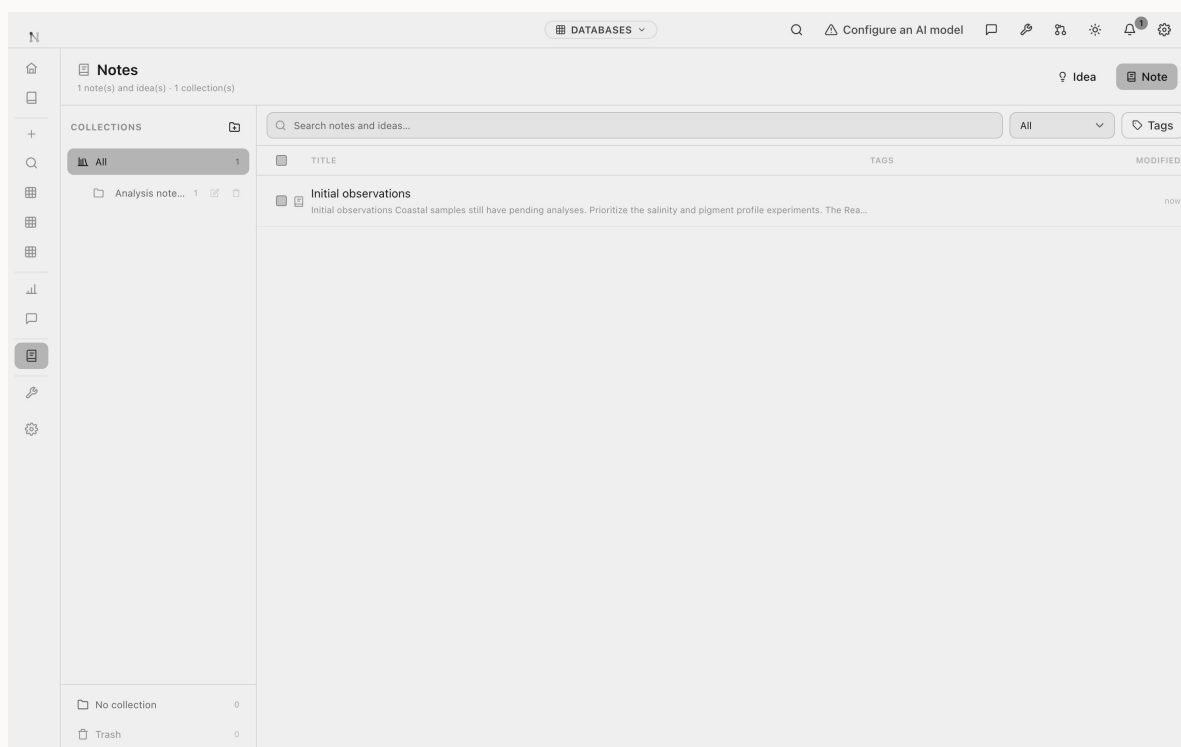
Databases vault → Database-linked notes

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a note for a method, issue or finding.
2. Link the affected database or records.
3. Record the decision, date and consequence for later analysis.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Maintain a data dictionary and change log from the beginning.



Database-linked notes in the Nodus desktop application

CONFIGURE

13 Database settings and safety

Control import behaviour, models, integrations and recoverable storage.

Settings combine local database maintenance with shared model, MCP and backup controls.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Databases vault → Database settings and safety

STEP BY STEP

1. Review provider and model choices for analysis and AI columns.
2. Test MCP access with a read-only client before exposing write operations.
3. Enable automatic backups and export critical datasets periodically.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Treat schema migrations and bulk edits as high-risk changes deserving a backup.

REFERENCE

Completion checklist

- The vault scope and name match the project.
- Sources or records have preserved originals and reviewed metadata.
- Generated interpretations have been checked against their evidence.
- Optional providers and integrations use only the intended data.
- Exports have been proofread in their final format.
- A recent backup has been created and verified.

This manual documents the desktop workflow represented in Nodus 4.1. Interface details may evolve between releases; the in-app privacy notice and release notes govern the exact behaviour of the installed version.